

ever dwells at the core of all—past, present, and future.

In conclusion

Having said all these amazing things, the upanishad brings us back to the heart of it all: Om.

“The Fourth, the Self, is OM, the indivisible syllable. This syllable is unutterable, and beyond mind. In it the manifold universe disappears. It is the supreme good—One without a second. Whosoever knows OM, the Self, becomes the Self.” (Mandukya Upanishad 12)

Gambhirananda: “The partless Om is Turiya—beyond all conventional dealings, the limit of the negation of the phenomenal world, the auspicious, and the non-dual. Om is thus the Self to be sure. He who knows thus enters the Self through his Self.”

The partless Om. In its attempt to convey to our human intellects a bit of the glory of Om, the upanishad has considered It as having four aspects or “parts,” but in reality It is without parts, being absolutely unitary in Its nature. So the upanishad reminds us of this lest we mistake its intent and meaning. Just as we sometimes have to speak inaccurately to children to get our ideas across, so has the upanishad done with us. But now it corrects any wrong impression we may have gotten.

Beyond all conventional dealings. Swami Nikhilananda renders this: “without relationship,” meaning that we cannot “deal” with God as we do with a material object or another human being. Nor can it be spoken about as It really is, for It lies beyond phenomena—although It is the source of phenomena. We cannot “relate” to God, but we can know our oneness with God when we ourselves pass beyond all dual relationships.

The limit of the negation of the phenomenal world. We must realize that the Self is absolutely like nothing we know in relative existence, and therefore It is beyond the reach of any words. That is the intellectual side of the situation. On the metaphysical side we have to negate all “things” from our consciousness that we find in the phenomenal world.

The auspicious. Lest we think this is a losing or a giving up of something worthwhile, the upanishad tells us that the Self is the truly auspicious, the truly fortunate, and producing good fortune. We really only give up and negate a mirage in exchange for The Real.

The non-dual. The Real being non-dual, we discover that It is us! So we not only gain everything, we experience it as being us. We recognize ourselves as truly being “the kingdom, the power, and the glory.”

Om is thus the Self to be sure. Om reveals the truth of what the upanishad is telling us. Om is not a symbol or designator of the Self, It IS the Self. This can be known.

He who knows thus enters the Self through his Self. We enter into our true Being through the japa and meditation of Om—which is our eternal Self. There is no greater or higher knowledge than the knowledge of Om. And now the upanishad has given us that knowledge.

End of Mandukya Commentary:



Taittiriya Upanishad

Translated by Swami Gambhirananda

Published by Advaita Ashram, Kolkatta

Om ! May He protect us both together; may He nourish us both together;
May we work conjointly with great energy,
May our study be vigorous and effective;
May we not mutually dispute (or may we not hate any).
Om ! Let there be Peace in me !
Let there be Peace in my environment !
Let there be Peace in the forces that act on me !

Siksha Valli

I-i-1: May Mitra be blissful to us. May Varuna be blissful to us. May Aryaman be blissful to us. May Indra and Brihaspati be blissful to us. May Vishnu, of long strides, be blissful to us. Salutation to Brahman. Salutation to you, O Vayu. You, indeed, are the immediate Brahman. You alone I shall call the direct Brahman. I shall call you righteousness. I shall call you truth. May He protect me. May He protect the teacher. May He protect me. May He protect the teacher. Om, peace, peace, peace !

I-ii-1: We shall speak of the science of pronunciation. (The things to be learnt are) the alphabet, accent, measure, emphasis, uniformity, juxtaposition. Thus has been spoken the chapter on pronunciation.

I-iii-1: May we both attain fame together. May spiritual pre-eminence be vouchsafed to both of us together. Now therefore, we shall state the meditation on juxtaposition through five categories – relating to the worlds, to the shining things, to knowledge, to progeny, and to the body. These, they call the great juxtapositions. Now then, as regards the meditation on the worlds. The earth is the first letter. Heaven is the last letter. The sky is the meeting-place.

I-iii-2-4: Vayu is the link. This is the meditation with regard to the worlds. Then follows the meditation with regard to the shining things. Fire is the first letter. The sun is the last letter. Water is the rallying point. Lightning is the link. This is the meditation with regard to the shining things. Then follows the meditation with regard to knowledge. The teacher is the first letter. The student is the last letter.

Knowledge is the meeting-place. Instruction is the link. This is the meditation with regard to knowledge. Then follows the meditation with regard to progeny. The mother is the first letter. The father is the last letter. The progeny is the focal point. Generation is the link. This is the meditation with regard to progeny. Then follows the meditation with regard to the (individual) body. The lower jaw is the first letter. The upper jaw is the last letter. Speech is the meeting-place. The tongue is the link. This is the meditation with regard to the (individual) body. These are the great juxtapositions. Anyone who meditates on these great juxtapositions, as they are explained, becomes conjoined with progeny, animals, the splendour of holiness, edible food, and the heavenly world.

I-iv-1-2: The Om that is the most exalted in the Vedas, that pervades all worlds, and that emerged from the immortal Vedas as their quintessence, may he (Om that is Indra), the supreme Lord, gratify me with intelligence. O Lord, may I be the receptacle of immortality. May my body be fit; may my tongue be surpassingly sweet; may I hear much through the ears. You are the sheath of Brahman: you are covered by (worldly) wisdom. Protect what I have heard. Then vouchsafe to me who am her (i.e. Prosperity's) own, that Prosperity which brings, increases, and accomplishes quickly for me clothes, cattle, food, and drink for ever, and which is associated with furry and other animals. Svaha. May the Brahmacharins (i.e. students) come to me from all sides. Svaha. May the Brahmacharins come to me in various ways. Svaha. May the Brahmacharins come to me in the proper way. Svaha. May the Brahmacharins have physical self-control. Svaha. May the Brahmacharins have mental self-control. Svaha.

I-iv-3: May I become famous among people. Svaha. May I become praiseworthy among the wealthy. Svaha. O adorable One, may I enter into you, such as you are. Svaha. O venerable One, you, such as you are, enter into me. Svaha. O adorable One, who are greatly diversified, may I purify my sins in you. Svaha. As water flows down a slope, as months roll into a year, similarly O Lord, may the students come to me from all quarters. Svaha. You are like a resting house, so you become revealed to me, you reach me through and through.

I-v-1-2: Bhuh, Bhuvah, Suvah – these three, indeed, are the Vyahritis. Of them Mahacamasya knew a fourth one – Maha by name. It is Brahman; it is the Self. The other gods are the limbs. Bhuh, indeed, is this world. Bhuvah is the intermediate space. Suvah is the other world. Maha is the sun; through the sun, indeed, do all the worlds flourish. Bhuh, indeed is the fire. Bhuvah is the air. Suvah is the sun. Maha is the moon; through the moon, indeed, all the luminaries flourish. Bhuh, indeed, is the Rig-Veda. Bhuvah is the Sama-Veda. Suvah is the Yajur-Veda.

I-v-3: Maha is Brahman (i.e. Om), for by Brahman (Om), indeed, are all the Vedas nourished. Bhuh, indeed, is Prana; Bhuvah is Apana; Suvah is Vyana; Maha is food; for by food, indeed, are all the vital forces nourished. These, then, that are four, are (each) fourfold. The Vyahritis are divided into four groups of four (each). He who knows these knows Brahman. All the gods carry presents to him.

I-vi-1-2: In the space that there is in the heart, is this Person who is realisable through knowledge, and who is immortal and effulgent. This thing that hangs down between the palates like a teat, through it runs the path of Brahman; and reaching where the hairs part, it passes out by separating the skulls. (Passing out through that path, a man) becomes established in Fire as the Vyahriti Bhuh; he becomes established in Air as the Vyahriti Bhuvah; in the sun as the Vyahriti Suvah; in Brahman as the Vyahriti Mahah. He himself gets independent sovereignty; he attains the lord of the mind; he becomes the ruler of speech, the ruler of eyes, the ruler of ears, the ruler of knowledge. Over and above all these he becomes Brahman which is embodied in Akasa, which is identified with the gross and the subtle and has truth as Its real nature, which reveals in life, under whose possession the mind is a source of bliss, which is enriched with peace and is immortal. Thus, O Pracinayogya, you worship.

I-vii-1: The earth, sky, heaven, the primary quarters, and the intermediate quarters; fire, air, the sun, the moon, and the stars; water, herbs, trees, sky, and Virat – these relate to natural factors. Then follow the individual ones: Prana, Vyana, Apana, Udana and Samana; the eye, the ear, the mind, speech and sense of touch; skin, flesh, muscles, bones and marrow. Having imagined these thus, the seer said, “All this is constituted by five factors; one fills up the (outer) fivefold ones by the (individual) fivefold ones.

I-viii-1: Om is Brahman. Om is all this. Om is well known as a word of imitation (i.e. concurrence). Moreover, they make them recite (to the gods) with the words, “Om, recite (to the gods)”. They commence singing Samas with Om. Uttering the words “Om som” they recite the Shastras. The (priest) Brahma approves with the word Om. One permits the performance of the Agnihotra sacrifice with the word Om. A Brahmana, when about to recite the Vedas utters Om under the idea, I shall attain Brahman”. He does verily attain Brahman.

I-ix-1: Righteousness and learning and teaching (are to be practised). Truth and learning and teaching (are to be practised). Austerity and learning and teaching (are to be resorted to). Control of the outer senses and learning and teaching (are to be practised). Control of the inner organs and learning and teaching (are to be resorted to). The fires (are to be lighted up), and learning and teaching (are to be followed). The Agnihotra (is to be performed), and learning and teaching (are to be carried on). Guests (are to be entertained), and learning and teaching (are to be practised). Social good conduct (is to be adhered to), and learning and teaching (are to be practised). Children (are to be begotten), and learning and teaching (are to be carried on). Procreation and learning and teaching (are to be carried on). A grandson (is to be raised), and learning and teaching (are to be practised). Truth (is the thing) – this is what Satyavacha, of the line of Rathitara, thinks. Austerity (is the thing) – this is what Taponitya, son of Purusisti, thinks. Learning and teaching alone (are the things) – this is what Naka, son of Mudgala, thinks. For that indeed is the austerity; for that indeed is the austerity.

I-x-I: I am the invigorator of the tree (of the world). My fame is high like the ridge of a mountain. My source is the pure (Brahman). I am like that pure reality (of the Self) that is in the sun. I am the effulgent wealth. I am possessed of a fine intellect, and am immortal and undecaying. Thus was the statement of Trisanku after the attainment of realisation.

I-xi-1: Having taught the Vedas, the preceptor imparts this post-instruction to the students: “Speak the truth. Practise righteousness. Make no mistake about study. Having offered the desirable wealth to the teacher, do not cut off the line of progeny. There should be no inadvertence about truth. There should be no deviation from righteous activity. There should be no error about protection of yourself. Do not neglect propitious activities. Do not be careless about learning and teaching.

I-xi-2-4: There should be no error in the duties towards the gods and manes. Let your mother be a goddess unto you. Let your father be a god unto you. Let your teacher be a god unto you. Let your guest be a god unto you. The works that are not blameworthy are to be resorted to, but not the others. These actions of ours that are commendable are to be followed by you, but not the others. You should, by offering seats, remove the fatigue of those Brahmanas who are more praiseworthy among us. The offering should be with honour; the offering should not be with dishonour. The offering should be in plenty. The offering should be with modesty. The offering should be with awe. The offering should be with sympathy. Then, should you have any doubt with regard to duties or customs, you should behave in those matters just as Brahmanas do, who may happen to be there and who are able deliberators, who are adepts in those duties and customs, who are not directed by others, who are not cruel, and who are desirous of merit. Then, as for the accused people, you should behave with regard to them just as the Brahmanas do, who may happen to be there and who are able deliberators, who are adepts in those

duties and customs, who are not directed by others, who are not cruel, who are desirous of merit. This is the injunction. This is the instruction. This is the secret of the Vedas. This is divine behest. This is how the meditation is to be done. This is how this must be meditated on.

I-xii-1: May Mitra be blissful to us. May Varuna be blissful to us. May Aryaman be blissful to us. May Indra and Brihaspati be blissful to us. May Vishnu, of long strides, be blissful to us. Salutation to Brahman. Salutation to you, O Vayu. You, indeed, are the immediate Brahman. You alone I shall call the direct Brahman. I shall call you righteousness. I shall call you truth. May He protect me. May He protect the teacher. May He protect me. May He protect the teacher. Om, peace, peace, peace !

Brahmananda Valli

II-i: May He protect us both together. May He nourish us both together. May we both acquire strength together. Let our study be brilliant. May we not cavil at each other.

Om! Peace ! Peace ! Peace !

II-i-1: The knower of Brahman attains the highest. Here is a verse uttering that very fact: "Brahman is truth, knowledge, and infinite. He who knows that Brahman as existing in the intellect, lodged in the supreme space in the heart, enjoys, as identified with the all - knowing Brahman, all desirable things simultaneously.

From that Brahman, which is the Self, was produced space. From space emerged air. From air was born fire. From fire was created water. From water sprang up earth. From earth were born the herbs. From the herbs was produced food. From food was born man. That man, such as he is, is a product of the essence of food. Of him this indeed, is the head, this is the southern side; this is the northern side; this is the Self; this is the stabilising tail.

Here is a verse pertaining to that very fact:

II-ii-1: All beings that rest on the earth are born verily from food. Besides, they live on food, and at the end, they get merged in food. Food was verily born before all creatures; therefore it is called the medicine for all, those who worship food as Brahman acquire all the food. Food was verily born before all creatures; therefore it is called the medicine for all. Creatures are born of food; being born, they grow by food. Since it is eaten and it eats the creatures, it is called food.

As compared with this self made of the essence of food, as said before, there is another inner self which is made of air. By that is this one filled. This Self is also of the human form. Its human form takes after the human form of that (earlier one). Of this, Prana is the head, Vyana is the southern side, Apana is the northern side, space is the self, the earth is the tail that stabilises. Pertaining to that is this (following) verse:

II-iii-1: The senses act by following the vital force in the mouth; all human beings and animals that are there act similarly; since on the vital force depends the life of all creatures, therefore it is called the life of all; those who worship the vital force as Brahman, attain the full span of life; since on the vital force depends the life of all, it is called the life of all.

Of the preceding (physical) one, this one, indeed, is the embodied self. As compared with this vital body, there is another internal self constituted by mind. By that one is this one filled up. That self constituted by mind is also of a human shape. The human shape of the mental body takes after the human shape of the vital body. Of the mental body, the Yajur-mantras are the head. The Rig-mantras are the right side, the Sama-mantras are the left side, the Brahmana portion is the self (trunk), the mantras seen by Atharvangiras are the stabilising tail. Pertaining to this there is a verse:

II-iv-1: One is not subjected to fear at any time if one knows the Bliss that is Brahman failing to reach which (Brahman, as conditioned by the mind), words, along with the mind, turn back.

Of that preceding (vital) one, this (mental one is verily the embodied self. As compared with this

mental body, there is another internal self constituted by valid knowledge. By that one is this one filled up. This one as aforesaid, has verily a human shape. It is humanly shaped in accordance with the human shape of the earlier one. Of him faith is verily the head; righteousness is the right side; truth is the left side; concentration is the self (trunk); (the principle, called) Mahat, is the stabilising tail. Pertaining to this, here is a verse:

II-v-1: Knowledge actualises a sacrifice, and it executes the duties as well. All the gods meditate on the first-born Brahman, conditioned by knowledge. If one knows the knowledge-Brahman, and if one does not err about it, one abandons all sins in the body and fully enjoys all enjoyable things.

Of that preceding (mental) one this (cognitive one) is verily the embodied self. As compared with this cognitive body, there is another internal self constituted by bliss. By that one is this one filled up. This one, as aforesaid, has verily a human shape. It is humanly shaped in accordance with the human shape of the earlier one. Of him joy is verily the head, enjoyment is the right side, hilarity is the left side; bliss is the self (trunk). Brahman is the tail that stabilises. Apropos of this here is a verse:

II-vi-1: If anyone knows Brahman as non-existing, he himself becomes non-existent. If anyone knows that Brahman does exist, then they consider him as existing by virtue of that (knowledge).

Of that preceding (blissful) one, this one is the embodied self. Hence hereafter follow these questions: After departing (from here) does any ignorant man go to the other world (or does he not) ?

Alternatively, does any man of knowledge, after departing (from here) reach the other world (or does he not) ?

He (the Self) wished, "Let me be many, let me be born. He undertook a deliberation. Having deliberated, he created all this that exists. That (Brahman), having created (that), entered into that very thing. And having entered there, It became the formed and the formless, the defined and the undefined, the sustaining and the non-sustaining, the sentient and the insentient, the true and the untrue. Truth became all this that there is. They call that Brahman Truth. Pertaining to this, there occurs this verse:

II-vii-1: In the beginning all this was but the Unmanifested (Brahman). From that emerged the manifested. That Brahman created Itself by Itself. Therefore It is called the self-creator.

That which is known as the self-creator is verily the source of joy; for one becomes happy by coming in contact with that source of joy. Who, indeed, will inhale, and who will exhale, if this Bliss be not there in the supreme space (within the heart). This one, indeed, enlivens (people). For whenever an aspirant gets fearlessly established in this un-perceivable, bodiless, inexpressible, and un-supporting Brahman, he reaches the state of fearlessness. For, whenever the aspirant creates the slightest difference in It, he is smitten with fear. Nevertheless, that very Brahman is a terror to the (so-called) learned man who lacks the unitive outlook.

Illustrative of this is this verse here:

II-viii-1-4: Out of His fear the Wind blows. Out of fear the Sun rises. Out of His fear runs Fire, as also Indra, and Death, the fifth.

This, then, is an evaluation of that Bliss:

Suppose there is a young man – in the prime of life, good, learned, most expeditious, most strongly built, and most energetic. Suppose there lies this earth for him filled with wealth. This will be one unit of human joy. If this human joy be multiplied a hundred times, it is one joy of the man-Gandharvas, and so also of a follower of the Vedas unaffected by desires. If this joy of the man-Gandharvas be multiplied a hundred times, it is one joy of the divine-Gandharvas, and so also of a follower of the Vedas unaffected by desires. If the joy of the divine-Gandharvas be increased a hundredfold, it is one joy of the manes whose world is everlasting, and so also of a follower of the Vedas unaffected by desires. If the joy of the manes that dwell in the everlasting world be increased a hundredfold, it is one

joy of those that are born as gods in heaven, and so also of a follower of the Vedas untouched by desires. If the joy of those that are born as gods in heaven be multiplied a hundredfold, it is one joy of the gods called the Karma-Devas, who reach the gods through Vedic rites, and so also of a follower of the Vedas unaffected by desires. If the joy of the gods, called the Karma-Devas, be multiplied a hundredfold, it is one joy of the gods, and so also of a follower of the Vedas untarnished by desires. If the joy of the gods be increased a hundred times, it is one joy of Indra, and so also of a follower of the Vedas unaffected by desires. If the joy of Indra be multiplied a hundredfold, it is one joy of Brihaspati and so also of a follower of the Vedas unaffected by desires. If the joy of Brihaspati be increased a hundred times, it is one joy of Virat, and so also of a follower of the Vedas untarnished by desires. If the joy of Virat be multiplied a hundred times, it is one joy of Hiranyagarbha, and so also of a follower of the Vedas unsullied by desires.

II-viii-5: He that is here in the human person, and He that is there in the sun, are one. He who knows thus attains, after desisting from this world, this self made of food, attains this self made of vital force, attains this self made of mind, attains this self made of intelligence, attains this self made of bliss. Expressive of this there occurs this verse:

II-ix-1: The enlightened man is not afraid of anything after realising that Bliss of Brahman, failing to reach which, words turn back along with the mind.

Him, indeed, this remorse does not afflict: “Why did I not perform good deeds, and why did I perform bad deeds ? He who is thus enlightened strengthens the Self with which these two are identical; for it is he, indeed, who knows thus, that can strengthen the Self which these two really are. This is the secret teaching.

Bhrigu Valli

III-i-1: Bhrigu, the well-known son of Varuna, approached his father Varuna with the (formal) request, “O, revered sir, teach me Brahman”. To him he (Varuna) said this: “Food, vital force, eye, ear, mind, speech – (these are the aids to knowledge of Brahman)”. To him he (Varuna) said: “Crave to know that from which all these beings take birth, that by which they live after being born, that towards which they move and into which they merge. That is Brahman”. He practised concentration. He, having practised concentration,

III-ii-1: He realised food (i.e. Virat, the gross Cosmic person) as Brahman. For it is verily from food that all these beings take birth, on food they subsist after being born and they move towards and merge into food. Having realised that, he again approached his father Varuna with the (formal) request. “O, revered sir, teach me Brahman”. To him he (Varuna) said: “Crave to know Brahman through concentration; concentration is Brahman”. He practised concentration. He, having practised concentration,

III-iii-1: He knew the vital force as Brahman; for from the vital force, indeed, spring all these beings; having come into being, they live through the vital force; they move towards and enter into the vital force, Having known thus, he again approached his father Varuna with the (formal) request. “O, revered sir, teach me Brahman”. To him he (Varuna) said: “Crave to know Brahman through concentration; concentration is Brahman”. He practised concentration. Having practised concentration,

III-iv-1: He knew mind as Brahman; for from mind, indeed, spring all these beings; having been born, they are sustained by mind; and they move towards and merge into mind. Having known that, he again approached his father Varuna with the (formal) request. “O, revered sir, teach me Brahman”. To him he (Varuna) said: “Crave to know Brahman through concentration; concentration is Brahman”. He practised concentration. Having practised concentration,

III-v-1: He knew knowledge as Brahman; for from knowledge, indeed, spring all these beings; having been born, they are sustained by knowledge; they move towards and merge in knowledge. Having known that, he again approached his father Varuna with the (formal) request. “O, revered sir, teach me Brahman”. To him he (Varuna) said: “Crave to know Brahman through concentration; concentration is Brahman”. He practised concentration. Having practised concentration,

III-vi-1: He knew Bliss as Brahman; for from Bliss, indeed, all these beings originate; Having been born, they are sustained by Bliss; they move towards and merge in Bliss. This knowledge realised by Bhṛigu and imparted by Varuna (starts from the food-self and) terminates in the supreme (Bliss), established in the cavity of the heart. He who knows thus becomes firmly established; he becomes the possessor of food and the eater of food; and he becomes great in progeny, cattle and the lustre of holiness, and great in glory.

III-vii-1: His vow is that, he should not deprecate food. The vital force is verily the food, and the body is the eater; for the vital force is lodged in the body. (Again, the body is the food and the vital force is the eater, for) the body is fixed on the vital force. Thus (the body and vital force are both foods; and) one food is lodged in another. He who knows thus that one food is lodged in another, gets firmly established. He becomes a possessor and an eater of food. He becomes great in progeny, cattle, and the lustre of holiness and great in glory.

III-viii-1: His vow is that he should not discard food. Water, indeed, is food; fire is the eater; for water is established on fire. (Fire is food and water is the eater, for) fire resides in water. Thus one food is lodged in another food. He who knows thus that one food is lodged in another, gets firmly established. He becomes a possessor and an eater of food. He becomes great in progeny, cattle, and the lustre of holiness and great in glory.

III-ix-1: His vow is that he should make food plentiful. Earth is food; space is eater; for earth is placed in space. (Space is food; and earth is eater, for) space is placed on earth. Thus one food is lodged in another food. He who knows thus that one food is lodged in another, gets firmly established. He becomes a possessor and an eater of food. He becomes great in progeny, cattle, and the lustre of holiness and great in glory.

III-x-1-2: His vow is that he should not refuse anyone come for shelter. Therefore one should collect plenty of food by whatsoever means he may. (And one should collect food for the further reason that) they say, “Food is ready for him”. Because he offers cooked food in his early age with honour, food falls to his share in the early age with honour. Because he offers food in his middle age with medium courtesy, food falls to his share in his middle age with medium honour. Because he offers food in his old age with scant esteem, food falls to his share in old age with scant consideration. To him who knows thus (comes the result as described).

(Brahman is to be meditated on) as preservation in speech; as acquisition and preservation in exhaling and inhaling; as action in the hands; as movement in the feet; discharge in the anus. There are meditations on the human plane.

Then follow the divine ones. (Brahman is to be meditated on) as contentment in rain; as energy in lightning.

III-x-3-4: Brahman is to be worshipped as fame in beasts; as light in the stars; as procreation, immortality, and joy in the generative organ; as everything in space. One should meditate on that Brahman as the support; thereby one becomes supported. One should meditate on that Brahman as great; thereby one becomes great. One should meditate on It as thinking; thereby one becomes able to

think. One should meditate on It as bowing down; thereby the enjoyable things bow down to one. One should meditate on It as the most exalted; Thereby one becomes exalted. One should meditate on It as Brahman's medium of destruction; thereby the adversaries that envy such a one die, and so do the enemies whom this one dislikes.

This being that is in the human personality, and the being that is there in the sun are one.

III-x-5-6: He who knows thus, attains, after desisting from this world, this self made of food. After attaining this self made of food then, attaining this self made of vital force, then attaining this self made of mind, then attaining this self made of intelligence, then attaining this self made of bliss, and roaming over these worlds with command over food at will and command over all forms at will, he continues singing this Sama song: "Halloo ! Halloo ! Halloo ! I am the food, I am the food, I am the food; I am the eater, I am the eater, I am the eater; I am the unifier, I am the unifier, I am the unifier; I am (Hiranyagarbha) the first born of this world consisting of the formed and the formless, I (as Virat) am earlier than the gods. I am the navel of immortality. He who offers me thus (as food), protect me just as I am. I, food as I am, eat him up who eats food without offering. I defeat (i.e. engulf) the entire universe. Our effulgence is like that of the sun. This is the Upanishad.

Om ! May He protect us both together; may He nourish us both together;
May we work conjointly with great energy,
May our study be vigorous and effective;
May we not mutually dispute (or may we not hate any).
Om ! Let there be Peace in me !
Let there be Peace in my environment !
Let there be Peace in the forces that act on me !

Here ends the Taittiriya Upanishad, included in the Krishna-Yajur-Veda.



Taittiriya Upanishad Commentary

Commentary on the Taittiriya Upanishad—by Swami Nirmalananda Giri

Reflections On Brahman

In his translations of some upanishads Swami Prabhavananda omitted parts that were in such obscure language that any attempt at translation would really only be speculation. He also omitted very repetitious passages and those that dwelt with matters irrelevant to the knowledge of Brahman and the Self. I think that if you get complete translations of those you will see he was quite justified in this. Anyhow, I am writing this to explain why in the references to the verses of this upanishad there will be some jumping around.

Thou art indeed...

“Thou art indeed the manifested Brahman. Of thee will I speak. Thee will I proclaim in my thoughts as true. Thee will I proclaim on my lips as true.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 1:1:1)

This fervent profession of faith and fidelity seems quite simple, but when we consider what it entails, it is a high aspiration indeed. It is also strikingly in contrast to most of the upanishads, which continually insist on the transcendence of Brahman and the impossibility of comprehending or speaking of It.

While typing in the forgoing sentence my memory reached back to a time of blessed tranquility in the sacred city of Sukhtal in north India. Tradition says that the supreme Master Sukhadeva, the illumined son of Vyasa, came to Sukhtal and taught the dying King Parikshit the principles of Self-knowledge and liberation. Many centuries later I was in Sukhtal at a spiritual gathering (Samyan Saptah) under the aegis of Sri Ma Anandamayi. One of the great souls (mahatmas) also gathered there was Sri Yogeshwar Brahmachari, a venerable saint of Bengal whom I had met and visited with before. Every day he would be seated on the platform near Ma, sitting in profound meditation, not moving for hours or even seeming to breathe. The exception would be when he would give a daily talk on spiritual life. In the evening there would be a question-and-answer session with people putting questions to the various renowned spiritual leaders on the platform. One evening, right after a famous Vedantin had given a rather lengthy answer to a question, Yogeshwar Brahmachari began to speak forcefully. In a matter of moments the tranquil atmosphere was replaced by one of anger and suppressed violence toward him. It really felt like they were about to physically attack and maul him, the only restraint being the presence of Ma Anandamayi.

Naturally, the next morning found me seeking out Yogeshwar Brahmachari to find what had taken place, since everything had been said in Hindi. I found him happily ensconced in a cowshed (!) where he was sleeping on some straw placed on a stone ledge. I was very aware that not one of the other savants sitting on the platform day after day would have tolerated such humble and primitive surroundings. But Brahmachariji was very happy, as he could cuddle and talk to the little calf that was tethered nearby.

After some time of giving our latest news to each other, I questioned him about the previous nights' volcanic near-explosion. He laughed merrily and told me that he had challenged and rebuked all the “big Advaitins (Non-dualists)” sitting there, demanding to know why they harped all the time on the transcendence of God and ignored the divine immanence. “Why do you keep telling these people who have so many worldly involvements and problems that the world is unreal, that they should care nothing about it, and that to do otherwise is ignorance? In all these days I have not heard even one of you say just one piece of practical advice that would help them live their lives and remember God. They have come here at great inconvenience and expense, leaving their homes and work behind, seeking ways to keep from drowning in the world. And you just tell them the world is no more than a dream and to forget it! How could they forget it? How many children must they have to care for and how many debts and obligations? What is wrong with you? Why can't you tell them how to better their lives and rise above their worries and fears? You expect them to honor and support you, but what use are you to anybody? You should be ashamed!” He laughed and concluded: “So their Non-dual ‘realization’ and philosophy went out the window and they got very interested in a dualistic battle with me. If it had not been for Mataji being there I would have gotten some blows!” The thought of the frail saint being assailed by the “big Babas” who were as robust as their tempers, was not a happy one. But my dear friend was quite content with the situation, being firmly committed to the good sense embodied in this opening verse of the upanishad. What the Taittiriya Upanishad now will do is balance out the very true, though one-sided, teachings of some of the other upanishads regarding the nature of

Brahman and the world.

Thou art indeed the manifested Brahman. First we must understand that the cosmos is NOT Maya. Maya is the illusion in our mind as to the nature of the cosmos and our relation to it. Maya is a product of our ignorance, it is our wrong seeing and acting. The world “out there” is not Maya. Maya is the world “in here”—in our mind. Maya is the product of ego. Once this inner veil has been destroyed, then we see the world as God in manifestation. In reaction we then exult with the upanishadic sage, also saying: “Thou art indeed the manifested Brahman!”

Of thee will I speak. This will consist of two ways of speaking: denying what the world is not and affirming what the world is. We will speak of the reality of the world as Brahman. We will also speak of the unreality in the minds of ignorant human beings and explain its nature as delusion. Further, we will speak of the nature of the world as an evolutionary ladder, and explain how it is used by the yogi as the means of freedom and ascent.

Thee will I proclaim in my thoughts as true. We will see and know in our minds that which is real in the world, always aware that it is not “the world” at all, but Divinity Itself. This is a matter of knowing, not mere speaking or speculating.

Thee will I proclaim on my lips as true. And this truth will we both live and speak to others. The important point here is that we must know before we speak. Otherwise our words are just empty noise.

The true Knower revels in the affirmation expressed in this first verse.

Necessary Lessons

Protection

All sentient beings—not just humans—seek for security, for safety. “Shelter” means a lot more than a place out of the rain. It is commonly said that there is safety in numbers, but that it not true. There is only one assurance of safety, and the next verse expresses it rightly:

“May truth protect me, may it protect my teacher, may it protect us both. May glory come to us both. May the light of Brahman shine in us both.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 1:1:1, 1:3:1)

Satyam means truth, both relative and absolute, truthfulness, and Brahman Who is The Truth. Obviously, this verse is referring mostly to Brahman, but simple truth in the sense of accuracy and honesty is also implied. If Truth is possessed by both student and teaching, then it only follows that renown (*yashah*) and the splendor of Brahman (*Brahma-varchasam*) will accrue to them as well.

A lesson on Om

“Thou art Brahman, one with the syllable OM, which is in all scriptures—the supreme syllable, the mother of all sound. Do thou strengthen me with true wisdom. May I, O Lord, realize the Immortal. May my body be strong and whole; may my tongue be sweet; may my ears hear only praise of thee. The syllable OM is verily thine image. Through this syllable thou mayest be attained. Thou art beyond the grasp of the intellect. Vouchsafe that I forget not what I have learned in the scriptures.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 1:4:1)

This verse and those following are addressed to the Infinite, to Brahman, but there is a purpose for opening with a declaration that Brahman and Om are the same: what is going to be petitioned for can be attained through the japa and meditation of Om. We should look at these verses in that context.

Thou art Brahman, one with the syllable OM, which is in all scriptures—the supreme syllable, the mother of all sound. The more literal description is: “The Om that is the most exalted in the Vedas, that pervades all words, and that emerged from the immortal Vedas as their quintessence.” Om is the crown jewel of the Vedas—which includes the upanishads. All sound, including humans speech, is contained in Om—is actually a variation of the root-sound (mula shabda) that is Om. All words, then, are permutations of Om. This indicates that the faculty of speech is the supreme faculty in human beings, the one that most directly links them to their Divine Source—that actually Om IS their Source. The quintessence of the Vedas is the Divine Vision which is their very basis. And Om is identical to that Illumination. No wonder, then, that Patanjali tells us that the japa and meditation of Om is the way to the highest realization. (Yoga Sutas 1:28) Or that the Mundaka Upanishad urges us to “dismiss other utterances.” (Mundaka Upanishad 2.2.5) We should let go of the chitter-chatter of the mind and its irrelevant thoughts and constantly repeat Om. For the Mundaka Upanishad says in the next part of the verse: “This [Om] is the bridge to immortality.”

Do thou strengthen me with true wisdom. True wisdom is knowledge of the True (Sat), the knowledge of God. Nothing can impart such knowledge but God—and Om is God. So It is the only way to that knowledge. Om is that “one thing which, when known...all is known.”

May I, O Lord, realize the Immortal. Here, too, Om is the means. Swami Gambhirananda renders this phrase: “May I be the receptacle of immortality.” If we continually fill our consciousness with the invocation of Om we shall be vessels of immortality, of Brahman.

May my body be strong and whole; may my tongue be sweet; may my ears hear only praise of thee. Through Om even our external, material life becomes spiritually glorified.

The syllable OM is verily thine image. Through this syllable thou mayest be attained. There is no need for comment on this—what we need is experience of its truth through our own spiritual practice.

Thou art beyond the grasp of the intellect. Vouchsafe that I forget not what I have learned in the scriptures. Since the nature of Brahman—and therefore of Om, as well—is beyond conception and words, it is only natural that we keep forgetting the Truth of them both, just as Arjuna kept forgetting the true nature of Krishna. Since right now we are not consciously established in the Being of Brahman/Om, the fact keeps slipping away from us. For that reason we need to set the scriptural statements regarding Om most firmly in our minds. For the moment, at least, we need to let the sacred texts “remember” for us.

“Thou art the source of all happiness and of all prosperity. Do thou come to me as the goddess of prosperity and shower thy blessings upon me. May the seekers after truth gather round me, may they come from everywhere, that I may teach them thy word.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 1:4:2)

Om is the Manifest of all, so It is the source of all abundance, spiritual and material. Lakshmi, the Goddess of Prosperity, is, like all the other “gods,” a symbol of Om. As we see here, there is no fault in the yogi aspiring to material fulfillment so he can have his mind free to be fixed on the awareness of God.

It is noteworthy that it is not only lawful to desire material welfare, we should also desire to impart to worthy souls around us the truth of “Thy Word”—Om. We should all to some extent be yogacharyas—teachers of yoga. We must share our spiritual wealth with others. “Freely ye have received, freely give.” (Matthew 10:8)

“May I be a glory among men. May I be richer than the richest. May I enter into thee, O Lord; and mayest thou reveal thyself unto me. Purified am I by thy touch, O Lord of manifold forms.

Thou art the refuge of those who surrender themselves to thee. Reveal thyself to me. Make me thine own. I take my refuge in thee.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 1:4:3) This says a lot:

May I be a glory among men. This is not a bid for fame as some translators think. As Swami Prabhavananda understands, our desire must be to manifest glorious humanity on our way to divinity. Even if no one knows we exist, we can still through our sadhana be “a glory among men.” That is a worthy ambition, realized through Om.

May I be richer than the richest. This is done by possessing everything in Infinite Consciousness. What is mere money—or even a mere universe—in comparison to that? Om is Infinite Consciousness.

May I enter into thee, O Lord; and mayest thou reveal thyself unto me. “O Adorable One, may I enter into Thee. O Venerable One, enter into me.” This is Gambhirananda’s rendering. This is the great “Meeting of the Twain.” We unite with Om and Om unites with us.

Purified am I by thy touch, O Lord of manifold forms.

“Om! This Syllable is Brahman. ...With frequent application of this divine sound he washes away the stains of the soul.” (Amritabindu Upanishad 20)

“The meditation on Om should not be discontinued. With this divine mantra one should meditate many times for ridding himself of his own impurities.” (Amritanada Upanishad 20)

“The Taraka-Nama [Om], annihilates all sins. The Supreme Brahman shines in him who takes to this Taraka-Nama.” (Sannyasa Upanishad)

“The Pranava [Om] burns away sins;...Hence the Pranava removes all obstacles and destroys all defects.” (Varaha Upanishad 5:68,71)

“The Pranava shall be recited and repeated by those who desire all their sins annihilated.” (Shiva Purana, Vidyeshwarasamhita 17:15)

“Japa of Om purifies the mind.” (Shiva Purana)

“If the devotee repeats the Pranava he becomes pure.” (Shiva Purana, Vidyeshwarasamhita 17:18)

“Just as the bow is the cause of the arrow’s hitting the target, so Om is the bow that brings about the soul’s entry into the Immutable. For the soul when purified by the repetition of Om gets fixed in Brahman with the help of Om without any hindrance, just as an arrow shot from a bow gets transfixed in the target.” (Shankara, *Commentary on the Mundaka Upanishad*)

Thou art the refuge of those who surrender themselves to thee. Om is the safe haven of the sadhaka.

Reveal thyself to me. It is by the experiencing of Om in its higher and higher (subtler and subtler) forms that It is fully revealed and united with in meditation.

Make me thine own. By ending all separation from Thee. Though we ask the divine blessing for this, it is our effort that enables the Pranava to truly be The Word of Life for us.

I take my refuge in thee. As they often say in India: Japa-Tapa; japa-tapa; japa-tapa. By holding on to Om as “dear life” we enter into Life Itself.

A lesson on Brahman

Now Brahman is addressed in words of those that have crossed the sea of samsara and entered the harbor of the Supreme Self. Rather than obscure them with comments, I will give them just as they are for your inspiration.

“Thou art the Lord, immortal, self-luminous, and of golden effulgence, within the lotus of every heart. Within the heart art thou revealed to those that seek thee.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 1:6:1)

“He who dwells in thee becomes king over himself. He controls his wandering thoughts. He becomes master of his speech and of all his organs of sense. He becomes master of his intellect. Thou art Brahman, whose form is invisible, like ether; whose Self is truth. Thou art perfect peace and immortality, the solace of life, the delight of the mind. May I worship thee!” (Taittiriya Upanishad 1:6:2)

“Om is Brahman. OM is all. He who meditates on OM attains to Brahman.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 1.8.1)

“Having attained to Brahman, a sage declared: “I am life. My glory is like the mountain peak. I am established in the purity of Brahman. I have attained the freedom of the Self. I am Brahman, self-luminous, the brightest treasure. I am endowed with wisdom. I am immortal, imperishable.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 1.10.1)

A lesson on learning

To conclude the first part (adhyaya) of the upanishad, we are given a four-verse exhortation to a student who is departing from the teacher’s house after the completion of his study. It is fitting for all who are involved in “the world” or society to any degree to take these words to heart. For without them we will lose our way, however much we may have read and learned.

“Let your conduct be marked by right action, including study and teaching of the scriptures; by truthfulness in word, deed, and thought; by self-denial and the practice of austerity; by poise and self-control; by performance of the everyday duties of life with a cheerful heart and an unattached mind.

“Speak the truth. Do your duty. Do not neglect the study of the scriptures. Do not cut the thread of progeny. Swerve not from truth. Deviate not from the path of good. Revere greatness.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 1:11:1)

If we seriously intend to get anywhere in spiritual life, these principles will guarantee our success—as surely as their neglect or omission will guarantee our failure. Spiritual life is not a lark or a bit of spice to add to life. And absolutely it is not some emollient to make a negative and foolish life somehow tolerable. Many years ago at the beginning of the yoga boom sparked off by the Beatles I began outlining a book to be called *Is Yoga For You?* My intention was to warn people away from wasting their time with yoga if they intended to live a life incompatible with yoga’s fundamental character. But I soon realized that it would be a waste of time to write a book for spiritual idlers and dabblers who really would not care whether they succeeded or failed—they just wanted a diversion and something to impress others with, a topic for conversation. But now is the time for the facts to be set forth. I hope the authority of the upanishads will carry sufficient weight.

Let your conduct be marked by right action. There could be many lists of what constitutes right action, but the best is that of Patanjali the master yogi:

1. Ahimsa: non-violence, non-injury, harmlessness.

2. Satya: truthfulness, honesty.
3. Asteya: non-stealing, honesty, non-misappropriateness.
4. Brahmacharya: sexual continence in thought, word and deed as well as control of all the senses.
5. Aparigraha: non-possessiveness, non-greed, non-selfishness, non-acquisitiveness.
6. Shaucha: purity, cleanliness.
7. Santosha: contentment, peacefulness.
8. Tapas: austerity, practical (i.e., result-producing) spiritual discipline.
9. Swadhyaya: introspective self-study, spiritual study.
10. Ishwarapranidhana: offering of one's life to God.

Ahimsa involves gentleness, kindness, mercy, and abstinence from taking life—a matter that necessitates a vegetarian diet. Ishwarapranidhana is not just some noble or sentimental vowing of our life to God, but a very real and practical manner of ordering our life so that every moment brings us closer to God-realization, to union with God.

Including study and teaching of the scriptures. Being justly weary of being beaten over the head by “The Word of God,” both Westerners and Middle-Easterners naturally shy away from the idea of scriptural authority, whether the Torah, the Bible, or the Koran. But they misunderstand the very motivation behind reverence for scriptures in the East. Hinduism, Buddhism, and Taoism do not respect their spiritual texts because of who has spoken them or written them down. Rather, the value of the scriptures rest solely upon their practical value—nothing else. For them, a principle is not true just because it is written in a holy book, rather it was written in the holy book because it was the truth—a truth that can be put to the test and demonstrated to be true. For example, water is not hydrogen and oxygen because a science book says so; the book says so because it is true. The only reason we who follow Eastern religions quote scriptures is because they say it so well—often much clearer than we could on our own. The upanishads and the Bhagavad Gita are masterpieces of concise expression. Worlds of meaning often lie within a single phrase, even a single word. The bottom line is this: the Eastern scriptures WORK. For thousands of years multitudes have proven in their own life that Patanjali's list has practical value. And so can we. It is also our duty to teach what we know to others who are sincere and qualified. Whether by informal conversation, giving of books to read, or formal instruction, we must help others as we have been helped.

By truthfulness in word, deed, and thought. It is so important to realize that truth is not a verbal formula, but a way of life, a state of mind. We must *live* truthfully. Since God is the ultimate truth, we must live “godly.”

By self-denial. Here, too, the East means something totally different from the negative “mortification” of Western religion that is nothing more than an expression of self-loathing, a declaration of human “vileness” rather than the divine nature we “Orientals” know to be the truth of ourselves. In the East, “self-denial” means discipline and control of the egoic impulses to indulgence and laziness. It means not slipping into the morass of sensuality and selfishness. Basically it is ignoring the false ego to foster the true Self, the Spirit.

And the practice of austerity. This is not “mortification” or “penance” either. Tapasya is any practice

which rouses up and expresses our inner virtue, which clears the way for the revelation of our divine nature. It is not “self-denial” in the Western sense, it is Self-affirmation through spiritual practices that produce results in freeing us from ignorance and limitation.

By poise and self-control. I cannot recall ever hearing anyone exhort someone to cultivate dignity, we are so obsessed with the “plain folks” syndrome that we equate with democracy. How it can be considered a compliment to refer to someone as being “comfortable as an old shoe” is quite beyond me—perhaps an indication of my Eastern samskaras. The sadhaka should have dignity and even an intelligent reserve in dealing with others. This should arise from respect, both for himself and for others. We need not be artificial and put on airs, acting like “Lady Bottomley’s plush horse” (a favorite expression of my father), but we should act with self-respect and awareness. (It was called “circumspection” in a more sensible era.) Anyway, you get the idea.

By performance of the everyday duties of life with a cheerful heart and an unattached mind. This is possible only for a yogi. Cheerfulness is a natural side-effect of valid yoga practice. When you see a “yogi” that is not happy and optimistic, then either the yoga is no good or it is not being practiced. I am not speaking of the manic behavior of some “yogis” that were either cracked before they started yoga or the yoga cracked them. (I am referring to those that laugh raucously at the slightest expression of humor, or grin/smile all the time no matter what. These are the “yoga clowns” whose motto seems to be “Happy, Happy, Joy, Joy.” I heard of a man who once remarked to some of these yoga-hebephrenics: “You know, the way you all smile all the time is spooky.” When they responded by grinning all the more he insisted: “No, I mean it—IT IS REALLY SPOOKY!”) As they say: spot the looney.

Yoga promotes cheerfulness, but so does “an unattached mind”—it may be the major factor. As the Gita says: “He puts aside desire, offering the act to Brahman. The lotus leaf rests unwetted on water: he rests on action, untouched by action.” (Bhagavad Gita 5:10)

Speak the truth. This is not easy, especially since you have to first know the truth. Patanjali claims that a person who speaks absolute truth at absolutely all times will find that whatever he says will come to be. Here is an example from the first chapter of the first edition of Autobiography of a Yogi available from Crystal Clarity Publishers:

“Another early recollection is outstanding; and literally so, for I bear the scar to this day. My elder sister Uma and I were seated in the early morning under a *neem* tree in our Gorakhpur compound. She was helping me with a Bengali primer, what time I could spare my gaze from the near-by parrots eating ripe margosa fruit. Uma complained of a boil on her leg, and fetched a jar of ointment. I smeared a bit of the salve on my forearm.

““Why do you use medicine on a healthy arm?”

““Well, Sis, I feel I am going to have a boil tomorrow. I am testing your ointment on the spot where the boil will appear.”

““You little liar!”

““Sis, don’t call me a liar until you see what happens in the morning.” Indignation filled me.

“Uma was unimpressed, and thrice repeated her taunt. An adamant resolution sounded in my voice as I made slow reply.

““By the power of will in me, I say that tomorrow I shall have a fairly large boil in this exact place on my arm; and *your* boil shall swell to twice its present size!”

“Morning found me with a stalwart boil on the indicated spot; the dimensions of Uma’s boil had doubled. With a shriek, my sister rushed to Mother. ‘Mukunda has become a necromancer!’ Gravely, Mother instructed me never to use the power of words for doing harm. I have always remembered her counsel, and followed it.

“My boil was surgically treated. A noticeable scar, left by the doctor’s incision, is present today. On my right forearm is a constant reminder of the power in man’s sheer word.

“Those simple and apparently harmless phrases to Uma, spoken with deep concentration, had possessed sufficient hidden force to explode like bombs and produce definite, though injurious, effects. I understood, later, that the explosive vibratory power in speech could be wisely directed to free one’s life from difficulties, and thus operate without scar or rebuke.”

Do your duty. Dharma—here translated “duty”—is the way of life in accordance with the deep wellsprings of our personality—karma and samskaras. These comprise our fundamental nature, our prakriti. Through our personal dharma, our *swadharma*, we most quickly unfold our inner potential and stimulate our spiritual consciousness. It is so much more than a mere observance of “right and wrong,” “do and don’t.” So important is dharma, that the Gita tells us: “It is better to do your own duty, however imperfectly, than to assume the duties of another person, however successfully. Prefer to die doing your own duty: the duty of another will bring you into great spiritual danger.” (Bhagavad Gita 3:35) This is obviously a very serious matter

Do not neglect the study of the scriptures. This is not just a helpful hint, it is a major spiritual principle. True dharma is a lifelong study, and dharma is perfectly expressed in the eleven major upanishads (the Isha, Kena, Katha, Prashna, Mundaka, Mandukya, Taaittiriya, Aitareya, Chandogya, Brihadaranyaka, and Svetashvatara Upanishads), the Bhagavad Gita, the Yoga Sutras (Yoga Darshana), the Brahma Sutras, and the commentaries on them by Shankara. The Gita should be a daily study of the sadhaka as it contains the essence of all the others in a most practical and easily understood manner. For centuries many spiritual teachers in India have required their students to study the Gita daily. Much of the gross misunderstanding of Hinduism, and Advaita in particular, would be eliminated if the Gita were carefully studied and applied throughout the aspirant’s life.

Do not cut the thread of progeny. Now this is very, very meaningful. For centuries there has been the misperception that the teachings of the upanishads are somehow the property of monastics—that monastics are at the top of the spiritual hierarchy in Indian spiritual tradition. NOT SO. Not one sage mentioned in the upanishads was monastic, nor was a single author of the scriptures listed in the foregoing paragraph a monastic. Sanatana Dharma is founded upon the vision of the rishis—none of whom were monastics. Sanatana Dharma propounds four ways of life that are fitting for seekers after liberation. Only one is that of the totally committed monastic. It is certainly true that through the centuries monastics have been a major factor in the propagation of dharma, that the three schools of Vedanta were formulated definitively by monastics. Shankara, whose commentaries are mentioned also in the foregoing list of philosophical works, was a monk of monks.

Nevertheless, the life of the rishis, who were married and “in the world,” is the norm of Sanatana Dharma. Any philosophy incompatible with that is not dharma. At the same time, this also means that there is no room for spiritually lazy (and cowardly) people who try to shirk or shrug off their spiritual obligations by saying: “that is for you monks.” They do not want to be thought second-class citizens, but they want to live in a second-class manner and leave the complete fulfilling of dharma to the monks. Shame! There is only one spiritual life: the Yoga Life. Whatever the conditions or circumstances, all are obliged to be yogis. Otherwise their dharma is a sham, whether monastic or non-

monastic.

What does “the thread of progeny” have to do with this? The clear implication is that a Sanatana Dharmi (one who follows Sanatana Dharma) is duty-bound to marry, have children, and raise those children to also follow dharma—and yoga. The exceptions are those that become monastics from their youth or who have some impediment to leading a normal married life. “Footloose and fancy free” is not the way of the rishis. There you will see that Sanatana Dharmis are directed to have children, along with instructions on how to preserve brahmacharya in marriage (!). These are not the rules for monks, nor were they written by monks, as is clear. Behold for yourself how high the ideal is for ALL Sanatana Dharmis, whatever their stage of life (ashrama). Those who do not want to bother should leave dharma alone and join some cheap religion that lets them do as they please. There is a lot of it about.

Swerve not from truth. Patanjali says that the need for absolute truthfulness is “not conditioned by class, place, time or occasion, and extending to all stages.” One sign of a sociopath is the belief that he is not bound by the rules but is a law unto himself. There are a lot of spiritual sociopaths, but we cannot be one and survive spiritually. That is why the next counsel is:

Deviate not from the path of good. “The good” is learned by studying the scriptures and associating with the good—the godly. As Davey Crockett said: “Be sure you’re right, then go ahead.”

Revere greatness. Only those who can give respect—even reverence—are worthy of respect; only those who bow can rise. Those who cannot see greatness in others have no greatness in themselves. As the saying goes: “Mediocrity recognizes nothing above itself.” The capacity to perceive, value, and honor virtue, wisdom and holiness in another person is an essential ingredient in spiritual life. This is why those religions that open the way to liberation have great veneration for saint and Masters, in contrast to the “bow down and worship me” religions that can only guarantee earthly rebirth whatever their claims and promises may be. (The more they boast, the less they have.) The lives, teachings, and images of holy beings should fill our homes, keeping us aware that the ideals of spiritual life are attainable for us, too.

A lesson on respect

“Let your mother be a god to you; let your father be a god to you; let your teacher be a god to you; let your guest also be a god to you. Do only such actions as are blameless. Always show reverence to the great.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 1:11:2) The last two sentences have really been just covered, so we will look at the earlier ones.

First, the word translated “god” is *deva*. *Here* is the definition given in A Brief Sanskrit Glossary: “*Deva*: ‘A shining one,’ a god—greater or lesser in the evolutionary hierarchy; a semi-divine or celestial being with great powers, and therefore a ‘god.’ Sometimes called a demi-god. Devas are the demigods presiding over various powers of material and psychic nature.” As you see, *deva* in no ways means God—Ishwara, Bhagavan, or Brahman. It is indefensible to cite this verse in an attempt to coerce innocent people into worshipping some guru as God.

The meaning is as clear as it is simple. We should revere our mother, father, teacher (acharya), and even our guests as citizens of higher worlds. We need not be blind to their defects, for the gods have defects, also—otherwise they would be free souls and not gods at all. We should do our best to accommodate these earthly gods and to care for them with all love and solicitude. Here, too, exaggeration is not intended. If our parents tell us to commit wrong or damage or neglect our spiritual life we should ignore it, but as much as is sensible we should defer to them in a reasonable manner. This is dharma.

There are many who “do good” grudgingly as though taking bitter medicine, or with a kind of weary “after all it’s my duty” attitude. Many treat the objects of their “care” or charity in a rude and contemptuous manner or adopt the attitude of an exasperated adult toward a worrisome or recalcitrant child. This is not dharma. So the upanishad continues: “Whatever you give to others, give with love and respect. Gifts must be given in abundance, with joy, humility, and compassion.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 1:11:3) This is a high ideal, but I have seen it done in both America and India by Christians, Buddhists, and Hindus. All it requires is a pure heart free from ego and selfishness. One time In Varanasi I saw two people feeding hundreds of poor people. At the end of the meal, each person was given money and clothing. As they left, they walked by the benefactors who saluted each one with folded hands, saying “Thank you” to each of them. They understood: by letting them give in charity, those poor people were enabling them to create good karma for the future.

A lesson on right conduct

Anyone who has a developed conscience is concerned about accurately determining what right conduct really is. So the upanishad tells us: “If at any time there is any doubt with regard to right conduct, follow the practice of great souls, who are guileless, of good judgment, and devoted to truth. Thus conduct yourself always. This is the injunction, this is the teaching, and this is the command of the scriptures.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 1:11:4) Scriptures are important, but they are sometimes abstract, whereas the lives of saints show us exactly how things should be done. If we can have access to a living saint who will advise us, then we are most fortunate. But if not, we should seek out and read the lives of saints of all traditions and learn how to live. Often we may not at all care for the formal theology of a particular saint’s religious tradition, but his life transcends such things and shows how to live in a divine manner. (Do not forget: many saints have been persecuted by their own religion—even martyred. So we need not accept the religion when we honor the saint.) “Guileless, of good judgment, and devoted to truth”—such are the saints. And so should we be.

Those who learn and follow these lessons given us in the upanishad shall be wise indeed.

The Source and the Goal

Brahman

“He who knows Brahman attains the supreme goal. Brahman is the abiding reality, he is pure knowledge, and he is infinity. He who knows that Brahman dwells within the lotus of the heart becomes one with him and enjoys all blessings.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:1:1a)

This verse contains the famous formula: *Satyam, jnanam, anantam Brahman*—“Brahman is Reality, Knowledge, and Infinity.” The rest of the verse is self-explanatory, except the Sanskrit says that the liberated one knows “Brahman as existing in the intellect [buddhi] in the supreme space in the heart.” This is the seat of Om.

Food

“Out of Brahman, who is the Self, came ether; out of ether, air; out of air, fire; out of fire, water; out of water, earth; out of earth, vegetation; out of vegetation, food; out of food, the body of man. The body of man, composed of the essence of food, is the physical sheath of the Self.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:1:1b)

There are a few listings in the upanishads of the emanation-stages of creation, for it is essential to realize that everything has come from Brahman and shall return to Brahman. Naturally they are broad—

very broad—outlines, for the manifestation of relativity has countless subtle stages. First there comes the great elements, forerunners of the elements here on the physical level. When the physical planets are fully formed, then vegetation appears, and then human beings as abodes of the Self. Implied here is the principle that vegetables are the natural and intended food of human beings—certainly of those who intend to manifest the Self. The Gita and upanishads say a great deal about food because the mind is formed of the subtle essence of food. Vegetarian diet is a cornerstone of humanity, and a necessary factor in the aspiration to divinity. No serious aspirant can afford to ignore this or attempt to. So the upanishad continues:

“From food are born all creatures, which live upon food and after death return to food. Food is the chief of all things. It is therefore said to be medicine for all diseases of the body. Those who worship food as Brahman gain all material objects. From food are born all beings which, being born, grow by food. All beings feed upon food, and, when they die, food feeds upon them.”
(Taittiriya Upanishad 2:2:1)

This is a great deal of mental food to digest, but is well worth the effort. Food (annam) is not just something material that an organism subsists on, but includes everything that goes to affect any sentient being. Thoughts and feelings are food, and all life-experiences are food. Intuitions are food. Of course some are positive and some are negative, but they all go to “feed” the evolving consciousness. But frankly if we don’t start with the regulation of physical food we need not bother with the metaphysical food.

Food, physical and subtle, is the medicine for all ills. This the Indian sages knew long before nutritionists or naturopaths existed. I was fortunate to know a truly great man, Dr. Josef Lenninger, who could cure any disease with diet alone. He was never wrong and he never failed to cure anyone who followed his instructions. He even saved people’s lives—people that I knew. Diet is everything—this I learned from him much better than from any yogi.

When we realize that Brahman is the ultimate “food” then our spiritual health is assured. When we live in harmony with Brahman, all good comes to us on all levels of our existence. Just as bodies are absorbed in the earth from which they and their food came, so finally we are absorbed into our original Source to “life forever” in the greatest sense.

The Bodies of the Bodiless

“Different from the physical sheath is the vital sheath. This is encased in the physical sheath and has the same form. Through this the senses perform their office. From this men and beasts derive their life. This determines the length of life of all creatures. He who worships the vital sheath as Brahman lives to complete his span of life. This sheath is the living self of the physical sheath.

“Different from the vital sheath is the mental sheath. This is encased in the vital sheath and has the same form.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:3:1)

Just as God has encased himself in various layers of manifestation, so has the Self. So knowledge of these sheaths (koshas) is worthwhile.

The pranic and mental (manasic) bodies

Inside the physical body is the pranic body, the body of life-force. Without the pranic body the physical body cannot live. The pranic body is also the most objective astral body, and when seen looks just like

the physical body. At death, the grossest part of the pranic body remains, which is why the hair and fingernails grow for a while after death. When it separates from the physical body at death, the pranic body takes on the appearance it had when strongest—usually as the person looked in early middle-age. When projected from the physical while the person still lives in embodiment, however, it looks just like the physical body at that time.

Within the pranic body the currents of life-force move in subtle channels that correspond to the physical nerves. In Sanskrit both the physical and pranic “nerves” are called nadis.

The pranic body draws its substance from food, sunlight, and air. This latter is one of the reasons yogis pay attention to both diet and breathing. Health of the pranic body can produce health of the material body. The pranic body does indeed determine both the health and the length of life of the physical body. Prana is the very Life of God in manifestation, so we live in and by the Divine Life.

In a sense, the pranic body is the “self” of the physical. It is the link between the physical sense organs and the sensory mind, or manas, which is the mental sheath spoken of next. This body also has the form of the embodied person, but is more radiant than the pranic sheath. It, too, is astral, and draws a great deal of its vitality from the pranic body.

Their limitation

These three bodies are mostly integrated with earthly experience—that is their purpose. For this reason they perceive only the slightest hints of spiritual being—of Spirit Itself. Therefore the upanishad interposes this statement:

“Words cannot express the bliss of Brahman, mind cannot reach it. The sage, who knows it, is freed from fear.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:4:1)

This is tremendous information for the yogi. First, it tells him that any words about Brahman and Brahman-experience are worthless, even deceptive, since It cannot be spoken about, nor can the sensory mind perceive Brahman in Its pure Being. Next it tells him that those who know this truth will be freed from great fear and doubts. This is because ignorant people continually mistake physical, pranic, and mental phenomena for spiritual phenomena. Then, when the flaws—and sometimes outright false character—of those phenomena are discovered, the sincere seeker is thrown into doubt, fear, and confusion. Disillusionment with these things sometimes cause the person to forsake spiritual life altogether. Of course, spiritual life is impossible on those levels, so they never really had one—but they aspired to do so. We are being warned by the upanishad to not make similar mistakes. The yogi must continually live higher than these three levels. He must realize that they are delusive to a high degree. Nevertheless they are vehicles of the divine Self and must be cared for.

“The mental sheath is the living self of the vital sheath.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:4:2)

The mental sheath draws much of its power from the pranic sheath, as I said, but it greatly controls the pranic sheath and empowers it by directing it. For example, when the sensory mind sees attractive food, it stimulates the pranic sheath to begin the process of physical digestion. When it perceives something pleasant the two other bodies are likewise affected, and when it perceives something fearful or life-threatening its effects are sometimes cataclysmic.

The intellectual body

“Different from the mental sheath is the intellectual sheath. This is encased in the mental sheath and has the same form. All actions, sacrificial or otherwise, are performed through the intellect.

All the senses pay homage to the intellectual sheath. He who worships intellect as Brahman does not err; he does not identify himself with the other sheaths, and does not yield to the passions of the body.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:5:1)

Now the upanishad speaks of the jnanamaya kosha, the intellectual sheath, that is also called the buddhi, the intellect. This controls the three lower sheaths through intelligent understanding. Light strikes the eye and imprints an image of a tree on the retina, the nerves, physical and pranic, convey impulses to the physical and astral brains, the intellect perceives it and says: “That is a tree—a maple tree.” Without this function of the buddhi, we would not be human beings at all.

The intellectual sheath is not astral but causal. If we saw it, we would see light—usually formless, but on the lesser levels it could have the general outline of the human body. The senses are messengers to the intellect, its servants, actually. The wise yogi “does not identify himself with the other sheaths,” but centers his awareness in and directs his life mostly from the buddhi. As a result he “does not yield to the passions of the body.” Surely the buddhi is worthy of reverence.

The will body

“Different from the intellectual sheath is the sheath of the ego. This sheath is encased in the intellectual sheath and has the same form.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:5:2a)

The completion of the body complex is the highest body, the anandamaya kosha which is the seat of will and the sense of asmita—“I exist.” The intellect may know it is seeing a tree, but the will decides whether or not to keep looking at it. In this way it fully controls the lesser levels. It both brings them into function and stops their actions. Just as the buddhi makes us intelligent human beings, the will-body makes us effective human beings.

The anandamaya kosha is the subtlest causal level, so subtle that it “touches” and partakes of the nature of the spirit-self. Functionally speaking, it is a mixture of subtle energy and pure consciousness—though it is not really, since “beyond all sheaths is the Self.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:5:2b) Sometimes we have to speak inaccurately to get across at least a shadow of higher realities.

Karma

All intelligent thought and action are possible because of the buddhi and the will. So they are really the seat of karma. That is why Buddha taught that intention determined the nature of karma more than the act, that a person who accidentally brought about the death of another would not be a murderer. Someone who gives poison to an ill person, fully believing that it is medicine, is not guilty of taking life. Ultimately karma is a matter of the will, for it is the basis of action.

All together

These five bodies correspond to the five elements: earth, water, fire, air, and ether. They also correspond to five levels of existence: bhuh, bhuvah, swah, maha, and jana lokas. According to which body we mostly “live” in determines what world (loka) we will incarnate in after this life. Fortunately for the yogi, he steps beyond these five bodies and cultivates awareness of the Self. So at death the skilled yogi goes to tapa loka, the world of those who are consciously evolving themselves. Hopefully he will not return to earthly birth, but will continue on from there to the highest world, satya loka, the realm of the liberated ones who know Brahman.

Brahman and belief

Beyond the sheaths is the Self, and beyond the Self as Its inmost being is Brahman. Brahman is the basis of all and IS all, as the upanishad will soon discuss. This being so: “Vain and useless becomes his life who thinks of Brahman as nonexistent. He alone who knows Brahman as existent truly lives.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:6:1a) Interestingly, the upanishad literally says: “If anyone knows Brahman as non-existent, he himself becomes non-existent.” How many times do people “know” something that is completely wrong. Our belief in God must not be based on our ignorant mind like the unbelief of the atheist. I have known of people who became atheists when tragedy entered their lives, and I have known people who became believers when tragedy came into their lives. Neither their unbelief nor their belief really amounted to anything. People who come to believe in God as a kind of last resort are like conquered enemies, not free and loyal citizens of the kingdom of God.

We should not *believe* in God, we should *know* that God exists. There is a deep intuition of the existence of God in each one of us that comes from our spirit-self. But because of the mental debris we have accumulated in this and prior lives it has become greatly attenuated, distorted, or even obliterated. An external factor can sometimes shift the debris pile to let some light through, but how long will it be before other things shift it back? The only really safe and sure way is to practice meditation and burn up the things that are obscuring our intuition of spirit. Then we will be knowers of the existence of Brahman and well on the way to becoming knowers of Brahman.

Our minds possess the same creative power as the Divine Mind, though to a finite degree. Nonetheless, our mind determines our entire life—the whole course of our evolution in this and all higher worlds. It does rest squarely on us. Remember what Sri Ramakrishna said: The mind is everything. God has created the playing field and supplied all the equipment for the game. But how we play is up to us—none else. If we do not know either the goal of the game or the way it is played, it is hopeless. As the upanishad says, the life of one who does not believe in God is vain and useless. But if we know the goal, the rules, and the way to play, then we will play well—truly live, as the upanishad says.

The only reason for the universe is the attainment of Brahmajnana. So the upanishad finally says:

“Surely at death a foolish man does not attain Brahman, but only a wise man.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:6:1b)

Brahman, Creation, and Us

Brahman and creation

Now we are ready for the subject of the creation and its implications for both God and human beings.

“Desiring that he should become many, that he should make of himself many forms, Brahman meditated. Meditating, he created all things. Creating all things, he entered into everything. Entering into all things, he became that which has shape and that which is shapeless; he became that which can be defined and that which cannot be defined; he became that which has support and that which has not support; he became that which is conscious and that which is not conscious; he became that which is gross and that which is subtle. He became all things whatsoever: therefore the wise call him the Real.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:6:1c)

Desiring that he should become many, that he should make of himself many forms, Brahman meditated. Meditating, he created all things. Certainly the One cannot become two, much less many. But he can experience multiplicity through his omniscience. So he willed, and all things came into being through

his innate omnipotence. But it was totally an ideational process. The Cosmic Dreamer projected the cosmic dream. Then:

Creating all things, he entered into everything. Entering into all things, he became...all things whatsoever: therefore the wise call him the Real. Pervading all things through his omnipresence he became aware of them and experienced “being” them just as in dream we take on many identities and forms that constantly change until we awaken. Brahman, in contrast, is always awake and knows what “is” and “is not.” There is nothing that Brahman has not become, described and indescribable, sentient and insentient. Brahman “is” all things.

Swami Gambhirananda’s more literal translation brings about a point to be noted. “He wished, ‘Let me be many, let me be born.’” The Birthless actually undergoes birth. *And the same is true of us.* We have neither birth nor death. Experience is not reality—this we must learn.

“Concerning which truth it is written: Before creation came into existence, Brahman existed as the Unmanifest. From the Unmanifest he created the manifest. From himself he brought forth himself. Hence he is known as the Self-Existent.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:7:1a)

Gambhirananda’s more literal translation gives us a better idea: “In the beginning all this was but the unmanifested [Brahman]. From that emerged the manifested. That Brahman created Itself by Itself. Therefore It is called the self-creator” There is really no need for comment.

And us

“The Self-Existent is the essence of all felicity. Who could live, who could breathe, if that blissful Self dwelt not within the lotus of the heart? He it is that gives joy.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:7:1b)

Gambhirananda: “That which is known as the self-creator is verily the source of joy; for one becomes happy by coming in contact with that source of joy. Who, indeed, will inhale, and who will exhale, if this Bliss be not there in the supreme space [within the heart]. This one, indeed enlivenes.”

One becomes happy by coming in contact with that source of joy. Brahman is of the nature of bliss itself, the source of joy to all beings. It is clear and simple: by coming in contact with that source of joy we will be joyful. A lot of people are hyper and hysterical, and some are so heedless and unaware that they are “happy” like village idiots. But only those who consciously contact Brahman through meditation are truly happy and have inner joy—the only kind that is real and lasting. Seeking happiness in anything but God can only lead to unhappiness. How many “deliriously happy” people have we seen ending up in what John Bunyan calls *The Slough of Despond* in Pilgrim’s Progress? Their false joy evaporates so very quickly. Then they go running after another mirage. And another. And another.

Who, indeed, will inhale, and who will exhale, if this Bliss be not there in the supreme space [within the heart]. This part is of utmost importance to yogis, for it indicates that the breath arises from the Chidakasha, the principle (tattwa) of Conscious Ether, the abode of the Self. This is why all liberating yoga involves breath. For if breath arises from the Source, it will take us to that Supreme Bliss if we understand how to work with it. (See the chapter Breath and Sound in Meditation in *Om Yoga*.)

Knowing Brahman

This one, indeed enlivenes. This is why just a few verses back the upanishad says: “Vain and useless becomes his life who thinks of Brahman as nonexistent. He alone who knows Brahman as existent truly lives.” This is bedrock truth. That is why yoga is the Path to Life. The persevering yogi experiences

ever-increasing life on all levels of his being. “The path of the just is as the shining light, that shineth more and more unto the perfect day.” (Proverbs 4:18)

“When a man finds his existence and unity in the Self—who is the basis of life, who is beyond the senses, who is formless, inexpressible, beyond all predicates—then alone does he transcend fear. So long as there is the least idea of separation from him, there is fear. To the man who thinks himself learned, yet knows not himself as Brahman, Brahman, who drives away all fear, appears as fear itself.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:7:1c)

We reach fearlessness when we know our unity with the Self and Brahman. To attain this fearlessness our consciousness must become more and more centered in That which is “formless, inexpressible, beyond all predicates.” While living in this world we must inwardly dwell in the Transcendent Reality that is Brahman, that is our Self. For “so long as there is the least idea of separation from him, there is fear”—and with good cause. The life separated from God is no life at all, but a mirage of suffering, change, decay, and death.

Perhaps one of the saddest truths in any of the upanishads is this: “To the man who thinks himself learned, yet knows not himself as Brahman, Brahman, who drives away all fear, appears as fear itself.” We see this all the time. Intelligent people fear the idea of living in the state of unity with God lest they lose their “individuality.” They cling to death and call it life while avoiding life as though it were death. How will they get out of that state? Only by a lot of buffeting by what they call life. It is not God who punishes and forsakes us because of this wrong choice—it is the false world that does so from life to life. Yet we grasp in desperation for more of its fake appearances and run from our only Life. In my early teens I spoke with a friend about how wonderful it was to free oneself of “the good things of life” and turn to the Only Life. “Oh!” he exclaimed, “if I lived like that I would feel like I was in prison!” So he chose what the world told him was “real living,” and now he is a broken, miserable old man with nothing but alcoholism and sexual deviance as his companions. He chose imprisonment, and will no doubt do so in future lives, for enslavement becomes a habit hard to break.

“Concerning which truth it is written: Through fear of Brahman the wind blows and the sun shines; through fear of him Indra, the god of rain, Agni, the god of fire, and Yama, the god of death, perform their tasks.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:8:1) The entire cosmos and all the processes of personal life take place through cognition of God and his purpose. The “fear” spoken of here is awe which cancels out any possibility of defiance or disobedience. In the human being there should be a clear understanding that since God is All, life should be lived accordingly. Along with that should be the realization that God is our Self, that we are “obeying” our own nature in which is all joy, but outside of which there can be nothing but fear.

Measuring the joy

In the seventh verse this question was set forth: “Who could live, who could breathe, if that blissful Self dwelt not within the lotus of the heart? He it is that gives joy. Now the upanishad takes up that subject of the joy of the Self.

“Of what nature is this joy?

“Consider the lot of a young man, noble, well-read, intelligent, strong, healthy, with all the wealth of the world at his command. Assume that he is happy, and measure his joy as one unit.

“One hundred times that joy is one unit of the joy of Gandharvas: but no less joy than Gandharvas has the seer to whom the Self has been revealed, and who is without craving.

“One hundred times the joy of Gandharvas is one unit of the joy of celestial Gandharvas: but no less joy than celestial Gandharvas has the sage to whom the Self has been revealed, and who is without craving.

“One hundred times the joy of celestial Gandharvas is one unit of the joy of the Pitris in their paradise: but no less joy than the Pitris in their paradise has the sage to whom the Self has been revealed, and who is without craving.

“One hundred times the joy of the Pitris in their paradise is one unit of the joy of the Devas: but no less joy than the Devas has the sage to whom the Self has been revealed, and who is without craving.

“One hundred times the joy of the Devas is one unit of the joy of the karma Devas: but no less joy than the karma Devas has the sage to whom the Self has been revealed, and who is without craving.

“One hundred times the joy of the karma Devas is one unit of the joy of the ruling Devas: but no less joy than the ruling Devas has the sage to whom the Self has been revealed, and who is without craving.

“One hundred times the joy of the ruling Devas is one unit of the joy of Indra: but no less joy than Indra has the sage to whom the Self has been revealed, and who is without craving.

“One hundred times the joy of Indra is one unit of the joy of Brihaspati: but no less joy than Brihaspati has the sage to whom the Self has been revealed, and who is without craving.

“One hundred times the joy of Brihaspati is one unit of the joy of Prajapati: but no less joy than Prajapati has the sage to whom the Self has been revealed, and who is without craving.

“One hundred times the joy of Prajapati is one unit of the joy of Brahma: but no less joy than Brahma has the seer to whom the Self has been revealed, and who is without craving.”
(Taittiriya Upanishad 2:8:2-4)

Joy comes from knowing the Self and becoming free of all desire through the fulfillment that comes from union with Brahman.

Rising into joy

“He who is the Self in man, and he who is the Self in the sun, are one. Verily, he who knows this truth overcomes the world; he transcends the physical sheath, he transcends the vital sheath, he transcends the mental sheath, he transcends the intellectual sheath, he transcends the sheath of the ego.” (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:8:5)

This is the real Ascension, and only those who have done so are Ascended Masters. Just as God is untouched by all the worlds that have proceeded from him, in the same way the liberated yogi cannot be affected by his various sheaths (koshas), his own private “worlds.”

It is written: He who knows the joy of Brahman, which words cannot express and the mind cannot reach, is free from fear. He is not distressed by the thought, “Why did I not do what is right? Why did I do what is wrong?” He who knows the joy of Brahman, knowing both good and evil, transcends both. (Taittiriya Upanishad 2:9:1)

He who knows Brahman is freed from all karmic bonds and knows that what he did and did not do will

no longer affect him either in the present or the future. Having transcended both good and bad karma, he is free. Sri Ramakrishna described such a person as being like a fish that had been caught in the net but has jumped out into freedom and swims joyfully away.

The Ladder of Understanding

Life is change; nothing ever stands still. When you do find something that is without any kind of change, then that thing is dead—including a lot of religion. A worthy spiritual aspirant is steady and unwavering in his aspiration and his endeavor, but he is always changing, for he is ever learning. He continually sees things either differently or better than before. To show us this, the upanishad is giving the account of Bhrigu's search for knowledge of Brahman. In the Gita (10:25) Krishna says: "Among the great sages I am Bhrigu," so this is a very important teaching that is being given us.

Know Brahman...

"Bhrigu, respectfully approaching his father Varuna, said: 'Sir, teach me Brahman.' Varuna explained to him the physical sheath and the vital sheath and the functions of the senses, and added: 'He from whom all beings are born, in whom they live, being born, and to whom at death they return—seek to know him. He is Brahman.'" (Taittiriya 3.1.1)

It is absolutely necessary to "know the territory" in any endeavor, whatever its kind. If equipment is involved, we must know and understand it thoroughly. This is why Oriental religions are so intent on the makeup of the human being. First we have to be a conscious human before we can move on to the next level of evolution. Therefore Varuna taught Bhrigu about the gross and subtle bodies, pointing out to him that all these have proceeded from Brahman—are reflections of Brahman—and that dealing with them is dealing with Brahman in manifestation. Brahman is the totality of all being.

Gambhirananda gives a better version of the latter part of this verse: "Crave to know that from which all these beings take birth, that by which they live after being born, that towards which they move and into which they merge. That is Brahman." The first point is that we should not just seek to know Brahman, we must crave to know It—there must be an intense hunger, a sense of absolute necessity, a life-and-death attitude behind us. For that is the fuel that propels us onward to realization. At the same time, we are not going against the current, but cooperating with the Eternal Flow, for all beings move toward Brahman through the many stages of evolution, and eventually merge into Brahman. This is the only natural mode of life, the only way of life which puts an end to all suffering and brings supreme fulfillment.

Tapasya

"Bhrigu practiced austerity and meditation. Then it seemed to him that food was Brahman. For of food all beings are born, by food they are sustained, being born, and into food they enter after death. This knowledge, however, did not satisfy him. He again approached his father Varuna and said: 'Sir, teach me Brahman.' Varuna replied: 'Seek to know Brahman by meditation. Meditation is Brahman.'" (Taittiriya 3.2.1)

Bhrigu was highly intelligent, so his concept of "food" was not just what humans eat to stay alive. Rather, as in the teachings of the Prashna Upanishad, "food" is emblematic of anything that sustains or is assimilated to the evolving organism and the inner consciousness. But even that did not satisfy him, for it was too "here and now" while Reality is mostly transcendent. Varuna opened new vistas for him by saying that Tapasya is Brahman. In A Brief Sanskrit Glossary we find this definition: "*Tapasya*: Austerity, practical (i.e., result-producing) spiritual discipline; spiritual force. Literally it means the

generation of heat or energy, but is always used in a symbolic manner, referring to spiritual practice and its effect, especially the roasting of karmic seeds, the burning up of karma.” Who else but Brahman can incinerate the seeds of karma? Although tapasya includes specific methods of spiritual practice, ultimately it is the power of release, of transmutation into Perfect Being. So tapasya in the highest sense is the active power of Brahman that IS Brahman bringing about liberation (moksha). Tapasya is Brahman within us. This should be the yogi’s constant perspective. But tapasya is the means, not the end, so the search continues. It is necessary to realize this, for some people meditate a bit, get a little experience, and think they are enlightened and know the mysteries of the universe. But, like Bhṛigu, we must never be satisfied. Sri Ramakrishna told the following parable:

“Once upon a time a wood-cutter went into a forest to cut wood. Suddenly he came upon a Brahmachari [a monk]. The Brahmachari told him, ‘My good man, go forward.’ The wood-cutter upon returning home began to think, ‘Why did the Brahmachari tell me to go forward?’

“A few days passed. One day as he was sitting idly the words of the Brahmachari came to mind. Then he said to himself, ‘Today I will go further forward.’ Going into the forest and moving deeper he discovered innumerable sandalwood trees. He felt happy and brought back cartloads of sandalwood. And selling them in the market he became a rich man.

“A few days passed and he remembered again that the Brahmachari had said, ‘Go forward.’ He returned to the forest and advancing deeper discovered a silver mine near a river. He had not even dreamt of it. Then he only mined silver and selling it made heaps of money.

“A few more days passed. And one day he thought, ‘The Brahmachari did not tell me to go up to the silver mine alone. He told me to go forward.’ This time going across the river he discovered a gold mine. Then he thought, ‘Ah! That’s why the Brahmachari asked me to go forward.’

“Again a few days afterwards, he advanced further and saw heaps of diamonds and other gems. Then he became prosperous like the god of wealth himself.

“Therefore I say whatever you may do you will find better things if you go forward. Do not think that you have achieved all that is there because you felt a little inspired. If you go still further you will find God.”

Primal Energy–Prana

“Bhṛigu practiced meditation and learned that primal energy is Brahman. For from primal energy all beings are born, by primal energy they are sustained, being born, and into primal energy they enter after death. But Bhṛigu was still doubtful about his knowledge. So he approached his father again and said: ‘Sir, teach me Brahman.’ Varuna replied: ‘Seek to know Brahman by meditation. Meditation is Brahman.’” (Taittiriya 3.3.1)

The word here translated “primal energy” is really Prana. Prana as used in this verse means the Vishwaprana, the universal life force that makes all things live. It is energy, but that particular energy that manifests as living things as well as the power of life itself.

Mind

“Bhṛigu practiced meditation and learned that mind is Brahman. For from mind all beings are born, by mind they are sustained, being born, and into mind they enter after death. Still doubtful, he approached his father and said: ‘Sir, teach me Brahman.’ His father replied: ‘Seek

to know Brahman by meditation. Meditation is Brahman.” (Taittiriya 3.4.1)

The word translated “mind” is manas(a), which means the mind of the senses, that which perceives the message of the senses. It is like the screen on which images are projected. For this reason it is very easy to confuse the mind with consciousness—indeed with the Self. But that is not so.

Intellect

“Bhrigu practiced meditation and learned that intellect is Brahman. For from intellect all beings are born, by intellect they are sustained, being born, and into intellect they enter after death. Not yet satisfied, doubting his understanding, Bhrigu approached his father and said: ‘Sir, teach me Brahman.’ Varuna replied: ‘Seek to know Brahman by meditation. Meditation is Brahman.’” (Taittiriya 3.5.1)

The word translated “intellect” is vijnana. This is one of those instances in which the Sanskrit has more than one meaning, and they are all intended. First, vijnana means the buddhi, the intellect, which is superior to the manas, the merely sensory mind. The buddhi is the intelligent, thinking mind, the faculty that hopefully marks humans out from lesser evolved life-forms. Since the cosmos is Intelligence, it is easy to equate the buddhi with that; but it is not so. The other meaning of vijnana is supreme knowledge, supreme wisdom, and supreme realization: the knowing that transcends mere intellectual knowing. It is the direct intuitive knowing of the spirit. This is so exalted that no one can be faulted for assuming it is the highest. But it is not, so:

Joy

“Bhrigu practiced meditation and learned that joy is Brahman. For from joy all beings are born, by joy they are sustained, being born, and into joy they enter after death. This is the wisdom which Bhrigu, taught by Varuna, attained within his heart. He who attains this wisdom wins glory, grows rich, enjoys health and fame.” (Taittiriya 3.6.1)

Ananda is the word translated here as “joy.” Ananda means bliss, supreme happiness, joy, and delight. It is a very dynamic experience, for Brahman is defined as bliss (ananda). So to experience this supreme bliss (Paramananda) is to be united with Brahman, for Brahman is that bliss.

Some reflections

This account of Bhrigu’s ascent to Brahman-knowledge has some very instructive points. First, no one needed to tell Bhrigu that he had not really found Brahman—his meditation-produced intuition told him that. So he was not deluded by any experience he had; rather, the experience led him onward of itself. Of course, all along he was intuiting Brahman, but only partially, and he knew that. And he knew when he finally had attained to complete realization, Purnananda, the Perfect (Total) Bliss. Equally important is the fact that Varuna never comments on Bhrigu’s experience or conclusions, but just keeps telling him to engage in tapasya. This is the way of the true Masters. They do not waste the aspirants’ time with hours and hours of theoretical philosophy, but urge them to find out the truth for themselves through the practice of yoga. This is the glory of yoga: it will reveal everything in time. It must also not be overlooked that perfection in yoga brings about abundance in this world as well. Many are the yogis who live simply and frugally, but that is their choice—the treasurehouse of the world is open to them.

Final teachings

Swami Prabhavananda skips some verses that are little more than a tedious recap of the “food” part that has gone before and comes directly to the meaningful verses at the very end: